I've got news from the others!

Vendredi hunts because movement keeps the ghosts quiet. Nata imitates his hero in an effort to bury his own.

Seasons in the Forbidden Lands are unforgiving. And when storms drive the herds, panic makes poor choices as a crowned Apex stirs beneath the thunder.

A Monster Hunter story about what courage is for, the promises you keep when nobody’s watching, and the moment a legend leans down to admit, very softly, “I’m scared too.”



Ch1 - Don't wanna live as an untold story

Vendredi breathed in the dry air, eyes closed, with a deep inhale through her nose.

It felt good.

Her raven-black braided twintails, streaked with purple, flew in the wind. A white scarf waved with them, graceful as the dance of Wind and Thunder Serpents. Sand goggles rested on her head, intertwined with stray hair bangs.

She hummed a familiar song as she adjusted her thick Arkveld-plated gloves, chains dangling from the wrists in rhythm. The desert breeze brushed sand against her exposed midriff. Her beige cropped top and white jacket, plated at the shoulders, were ineffective against the wind.

She didn't mind. Today's task allowed her to sacrifice protection for agility.

The sun warmed her medium skin tone nicely. She plucked a pebble from a pouch on her brown belt. Almost without thinking, she patted the scoutfly cage to check it hadn't slipped free during the climb. She twirled the pebble idly between her fingers as she dropped to a knee, the Chatacabra armor plates sewn into her loose beige trousers scrapping against the hard rock.

She took another big breath, admiring the swaying grasslands before her, perched on a rock formation near the sandy desert entrance.

The Windward Plains may have been the first place she discovered during her journey through the Forbidden Lands, and yet it still remained one of the most gorgeous sights in the region during the Plenty.

The lush savanna bloomed with vibrant plant life during the season. Large herds of Ceratonoths grazed across the plains. The four-legged herbivores formed a sea of scales, their brown dorsal plates rising in all sizes. Various insects and endemic life scoured through the blades of grass, birds flying low or resting on the few trees that offered refuge from the harsh desert sun. A group of migrating Amstrigian floated gently in the puddles to the West, water lingering from this morning's light rain.

Vendredi took it all in, the pebble flying mindlessly through her fingers as she committed each and every second of this moment to memory.

'Tsuki would have loved this.' She thought with a warm, sad smile.

The surrounding silence felt deep, somehow. The bustling noise of cities and Guild camps, where she usually rested, was gone. In its place came only the calming sounds of nature. The howl of the wind, brushing against the sand and lush grass of the savana. The rustle of leaves, intertwined with the happy chirps of birds.

It was peaceful. Familiar. It reminded her of simpler, younger days. Back before everything.

A sudden red flare rose up in the distance, sticking in the blue sky like a clean spot on a Jyuratodus' muddy gills. Vendredi got back up slowly, stretching in preparation for the task to come. She reviewed the plan in her head.

It was a simple hunt, overall. A sick Chatacabra who had unfortunately settled too close to base camp. She was to ambush and slay the monster, both to protect the researchers and local environment. An easy task she chose to relax on a slow Friday, her self-imposed rest day of the week, while two other members of the Alvis Unit had their own stuff going on.

Gemma, the blacksmith, had been called a day earlier to help out with Azuz' current Everforge Festival. The blonde had pulled her into a fierce hug before leaving, riding her Seikret with a warm smile on her face and a happy wave of the hand. The two-legged Bird Wyvern stood strong despite the heavy equipment piled onto it and the shifting weight of its rider.

Nata was soon to be home, finishing up his monthly tour of all the major villages around the Forbidden Lands. The boy had come a long way since she first met him, looking oh so small, standing in the Guild Leader's dark office. Staring up at her like a scared kid, a hand firmly gripping Alma's own, wondering if she was the supposed hunter who would finally bring him to what would be left of his home.

A happy sigh left her lips without her even realizing, reminiscing of those early days.

She had. She had brought him home, and so much had happened since. She never expected this child to worm his way to her heart the way he did. So bright, so full of life, curious, kind. He never gave up on returning to his family despite the odds. Even when faced with the very Monster that had ravaged his past, he chose understanding and compassion over sorrow and anger. And now, after finding his way back to his people in Wyveria, he had chosen to continue travelling with her.

She didn't have words to express how proud she was of the kid that viewed the world with wide, passionate eyes, that wished only to learn. He had decided on his own to act as the Guild's Intermediary for the various Villages of the Forbidden Lands, on top of his duty to the Keeper Clan's legacy and his training as an apprentice hunter.

Vendredi couldn't shake the smile lingering on her face as she fiddled idly with her dual blades, picked up from the ground. Knowing the kid, he should be swinging by Kunafa as of now, stopping for a meal at Y'sai's before coming back to camp. Maybe she'd meet him there with Alma after the hunt.

Speaking of, she saw from the corner of her eye a second flare rising up in the sky. Right- she got distracted here. The plan.

She closed her eyes again. She could hear the stomping footsteps of her target dragging in the sand, messily barreling through nature as critters and insects ran for their lives. The ragged breath of the beast was growing ever closer, ***hungry*** to devour its target.

Vendredi counted down.

5. She loosened her muscles, cracking her neck.

4. Her grip tightened on the dual blades.

3. One last breath.

2. Eyes still closed, she stepped forward.

1. Her feet touched the edge of the platform.

She let herself fall.

For a moment, she was weightless as wind rushed past her ears.

She enjoyed the rush of adrenaline as the ground grew ever closer. The feeling was ecstatic, like a drug. Her limbs were spread wide, slowing down her fall to make the moment last. Wind blew her face head on, sand brushing an old scar on her bottom lip.

She felt good. In motion.

Alive.

Vendredi opened her eyes mid air. A Felyne was running for dear life, chased by her target. The cat-like companion waved at her as he spotted her descent.

They had it exactly where they planned.

She shifted her weight slightly to adjust her position mid-air, contorting her torso.

The Felyne stopped at his designated position, gesturing and shouting loudly at the Monster to keep its attention on him.

Vendredi grinned, readying her weapon.

She finally reached the monster, and sank her dual blades deep into the side of its skull. Her speed let the knives penetrate the thick skin effortlessly, drawing a guttural cry of pain from the beast. The momentum carried her downwards, still holding on to the knives as she carved a deep gash along its head, slowing her fall until she landed softly on the ground. She instantly rolled back under a wide and confused paw swipe of the beast, stopping next to her Felyne friend.

She paused for a beat, examining the Chatacabra flailing confusedly in pain. The ape-like green amphibian was on the larger side of its species, its forelimbs looking thick enough to rip a tree from the ground. Its thick tongue sprayed on the sand, its spiky lower jaw open as it drew deep, rapid breath. The beast was obviously stunned by the sudden pain, the massive gash left by her blades coloring the right side of its face with a dual streak of dripping red lines.

Underneath the blood, two small black eyes found their way to her.

The beast's breathing got quicker, its temper rising in an instant. It roared, enraged at the sight of the hunter responsible for interrupting its meal and causing it such pain.

Vendredi stood at the ready, analysing the creature with a loose posture. The beast limped slightly on its left leg, its right eye covered in a thick stream of blood. Ragged breath betrayed clear exhaustion and illness. Its tongue didn't look as moist as it should, moving slower than what was usual for the species. The Binding Frog looked enraged, an angry puff of cloud from its snout.

She could take advantage of this.

The beast suddenly *lurched* at her. Her heart beat faster with sweat adrenaline as she dodged in the nick of time to its right, moving into its blind spot. She swiped nimbly a few times at its open wound with her blades while the beast turned and tried to hit her with its thick tongue. She easily jumped over the sand and saliva covered appendage, punishing the movement with a stab to the sensitive tissue, then landing near the Monster's left leg. Her second blade found its way to its knee, slicing a deep scar into it.

The Chatacabra groaned in pain. It dropped a shoulder to the ground, using its hind legs to drag itself on the sand and collide into Vendredi. The hunter managed to roll away in time, backed against a rock pillar. She looked up to see the top of it wiggling, clearly unstable. Vendredi grinned as an idea formed into her head.

In front of her, the Chatacabra recovered from its daze and puffed heavily, standing exhausted. Its eyes looked hungry, desperate for any form of sustenance.

"Inspector!" She yelled out to the Felyne, now lazily resting against a rock while surveying the scene. The cat wore a loose beige coat, contrasting against his dark fur marked with black spots and stripes. He raised a curious eyebrow behind thick goggles covering his eyes, holding a piece of cooked meat in his hands, ready to devour it. "Give me your lunch!" She ordered.

"What!?" he protested. "But- no fair! I've been saving this all day! And I was the one baiting this big fella here because *someone* wanted to stop for sightseeing!" He crossed his arms, pouting. "I deserve a treat!"

Vendredi rolled her eyes with an exasperated groan. “C’mon Bawlz, you’re my Palico. You’re supposed to do what I tell you during hunts, remember?”

The Felyne gasped in mock offense. “Excuse you, you hairless Congalala! I did NOT become a world-renowned inspector for you to boss me around like that!”

Vendredi snorted, forgetting all about the confused monster watching the scene as she put her fists to her hips and leaned over with a smirk. “Pfff- please, you wouldn’t be able to find a Deviljho in an open field! If anything, you’re more of my ‘emotional support Palico’.”

Bawlz deadpanned with her an unamused stare. “You do realize that’s *literally* why I’ve been assigned to you in the first place after you first ran off, right-”

A loud roar rudely interrupted him, the Chatacabra finally growing impatient with their banter.

Vendredi sighed. “Okay, okay I get it. Now, could you give me your lunch, *please*?” She asked, dejected. “Because we’ve got one hungry Monster in front of us who will no doubt swallow you whole if we don’t get rid of it right now.”

The Palico blinked behind his goggles, turning to the ape-like frog that stood a dozen times his size. The beast’s eyes were locked on to him, an open maw dripping with saliva. Bawlz now realized its jaw was wide enough to fit him **and** his whole extended family in the same bite.

Bawlz gulped and handed his meal to Vendredi, keeping eye contact with the creature as it turned its glance to the hunter.

“*Thank you*.” She insisted, overplaying her mock annoyance with a pleased smile. She turned to the Monster, exaggeratedly waving around the peace of meat. “Hey, ugly!” She shouted. “Yum yum is here!”

The Chatacabra roared, taking the bait in full. It lunged forward with surprising power and speed, barreling through the air towards her.

Vendredi grinned with a toothy smile. *Bingo*, she thought.

She let go of the meat last second, seizing back her dual blades with a firm grip, a dangerous glint in her eyes. She rushed *under* the flying beast, spinning wildly with her weapons as she struck a thousand cuts in a red blur. Time seemed to slow down for a moment as steel cut through thick but sensitive skin like butter, Vendredi moving forward in a grim dance of death. When she reached her final step, the Monster crashed hard into the rock pillar, which in turn collapsed in on itself. The beast flailed for a few moments, buried under rubble and drowning in its own blood.

The top, heaviest rock crushed its head with a sickening noise, putting an end to its struggles.

Vendredi stood there for a beat, breathing heavily with both her blades out, stature tight as if the Monster would suddenly get back up and fight. The rush of adrenaline was high, but it was quickly replaced with her own exhaustion as she realized the fight had ended.

She closed her eyes, relaxing her posture as she forced herself to slow down her breathing. Another job done. Another creature returned to the earth.

Vendredi didn't hear the light footsteps approaching in the sand, but felt a furry hand patting her leg. She opened her eyes to see the Inspector reaching up with a paw to her hand.

"... You okay pal'?" He asked softly, a frown behind his goggles.

"I'll be." She replied with a genuine smile. "You know how it is."

"Yeah…" He gave her a knowing look. "I… I'll go get Alma. Do what you have to."

She nodded wordlessly as he took off his paw, stepping away in the soft sand. She turned toward the felled beast, waiting until she couldn't hear his footsteps anymore to drop to a knee besides the creature.

Kneeling, she took out a carving knife as she prayed for its soul to find peace at Mother Nature's side.

The sound of steps on sand, the rustling of clothes and equipment, the chirps of Seikrets were all getting louder and louder as Vendredi quietly carved out another scale from the fallen Monster.

She didn't pay much mind to the noise, fully engrossed into the low hum of nature as she worked her way through the beast's corpse.

Vendredi enjoyed the moment of peace as she worked reverently on her task. The quiet in her mind, the familiarity of her movement… Some hunters found this part of a hunt to be chore. She didn't. It was… peaceful. Fulfilling.

Researchers would study the tissue and samples she had gathered, finding cures and remedies that would help people around the world. Undamaged scales and carapace would be turned into weapons and armor -- yet also medicine, clothing, tools.

A single hunt, a single merciful kill would end up helping countless lives. Such was the way of the Guild. Of nature.

She was pulled out of her thoughts by a warm hand to her left shoulder. Vendredi paused mid-carve. She turned her head.

Alma was watching her, a patient smile on her face.

The Guild Handler had a look filled with understanding and fondness beneath her glasses. Vendredi's tense shoulders relaxed on their own under her stare.

Her skin had a warm, sun-kissed tone that seemed to hold the light. Flowing brown hair was pulled into a dark green handkerchief. She wore her usual wide red coat despite the heat of the sun, a Guild notebook hanging around her neck tied with a lace. She had a flare gun at her belt, her free hand holding the reins of two Seikrets.

The two mounts stood patiently, both gnawing on some treat with their beaks. Alma's wore a brown and green plumage with hints of blue feathers under the tail, its saddle riddled with books and emergency field supplies. Vendredi's had a more colourful look, with bright green and yellow feathers with red tips on the head. Its saddle was carrying a second weapon, as well as a quiet Inspector Bawlz.

The Felyne and Alma shared a look, then Bawlz jumped off and took the reins from the Handler, bringing the mounts to a nearby patch of grass. Vendredi watched him slip away with a fond smile on her face as the Palico bickered with both Seikrets over stolen food.

She felt more than she saw Alma's gaze over her, waiting for her to speak. Her hand tightened around her carving knife for a second, the scale finally coming off.

"...Hiya." Vendredi eventually gave in, throat dry. She didn't bother forcing her usual enthusiasm into her tone, knowing full well she'd just get called out on it. She picked up the scale with her blood-stained hands and pushed it into a gathering bag.

"Hey," Alma answered warmly. "How was the hunt?" The Handler brushed off dust over her shoulder with one hand, the other grabbing her white Arkveld-plated gloves discarded in the sand, just as stained with red as the red of her armor.

Vendredi smiled despite herself. She always appreciated that about Alma -- the Handler didn't bother asking her if she was 'fine' or anything like that. She already knew the answer.

"Good." Vendredi answered easily, falling back to their usual rhythm. "Your timing was impeccable, the ambush worked-- thanks." She picked the tissue offered to her by the Handler, wiping her hands clean. "The Monster barely put up a fight!" She grabbed the gathering bag, closing it by pulling on the string. Alma hummed contentedly as Vendredi handed it to her, exchanging it against a vial of water the Hunter downed in a flash.

They sat down in the sand together for a beat, enjoying the silence that passed.

Eventually, Alma broke it.

"So." She said, gently. "Next week's the anniversary, huh."

Vendredi sighed.

“Yep’.” She confirmed, popping the ‘p’ sound. “... Five years.”

She felt Alma’s hand in her own, squeezing her fingers.

“... You know,” the Handler said. “It’s alright not to be okay. We’ll all be here.”

‘For you’ was left unsaid. But Vendredi could hear it well enough in her gaze.

She took a big breath. “I know, I know. It’s just-” Her throat tightened. She shook her head, gathering her thoughts. “Gog, I hate this.”

Alma just watched, patient. The silence stretched on.

“She’d be proud of you, you know.” Alma finally said.

Vendredi smiled, watching the horizon. The familiar sight of the plains, the sounds of nature, the warmness of her partner’s fingers intertwined within her own. She closed her eyes, the faces of her friends and found family flashing in her mind.

“...Yeah.” She replied after an eternity, opening her eyes again, full of hope. “Yeah, she’d be.”

Alma took her into a quick side-hug, before pulling off and cleaning her glasses with a tissue. “Come on now,” she said. “Let’s go back to Camp before Bawlz gets eaten by our rides.”

In the background, the Felyne was desperately trying and failing to protect his meal from the two Seikrets.

Vendredi giggled and bounced to her feet in an instant, holding out a hand to help Alma up.

“Better idea.” The Hunter grinned brightly. “Nata should still be around Kunafa village right now. Let’s surprise him before he gets home!”

Alma snorted in amusement. “Sure! He’ll be happy to see you.”

Vendredi pulled her back to her feet, keeping an arm around her shoulders as they walked to Bawlz and the mounts.

“Hey,” the Hunter said, her tone both gentle and serious. “He’ll be happy to see us **both**.”

Alma let out a fond sigh, parting from her arm to readjust the saddle on her Seikret. “Yes. You’re right.” She gave in, a true smile on her face as she climbed onto the Bird Wyvern.

Vendredi jumped on her own with a single bounce, Bawlz hoisting himself up behind her. “Of course I’m right! When am I not?” She teased with a shit-eating grin.

Alma shook her head in mock exasperation, not bothering to hide a snort. “Anyways, let’s go. Kunafa shouldn’t be too far.”

“Lead on.” Vendredi answered, their Seikrets already on the move.

Ch2 - The Eye of the Storm

Weather in the Forbidden Lands was a fickle thing.

Vendredi knew this after months travelling in the region. Yet, she was still caught off-guard once in a while with how **sudden** everything could change.

You could bask in the lush paradise of the Scarlet Forest during the Plenty only for a sudden downpour to rip trees from their roots with the swipe of a tidal wave in an instant. You could be plowing through the fierce, cold blizzard of the Iceshard Cliffs one moment and be met with the shine of a bright sun under clear blue sky the next.

Yet everything moved at a rhythm. Vendredi had long learned from the locals of the weather cycle that regulated the ecosystem.

The Plenty was a season of abundance. Vegetation would grow exuberantly, lush vines and bushes covering the old ruins of what once was. The change would draw a wide variety of herbivores to feed and reproduce, and within a few hours the region would blossom with an explosion in diversity of animals and monsters of all kinds. Villages would celebrate, crops would grow bountiful.

The Fallow was a season of scarcity. The climate would suddenly dry up, vegetation and herbivores disappearing in the blink of an eye, leaving carnivores to compete violently for the scraps that remained. Diversity would take a backseat to survival of the fittest in a difficult environment where only the strongest would survive.

Finally, the Inclemency was a season of disaster. Sandstorms would bury the once lush plains while thunder would rule the land. Heavy rains would cause tidal waves, the entrails of the Earth would explode with the sudden rise of magmatic activity, harsh blizzards would chip away at the remains of a discarded civilization. The environment would reset and lay the foundation for the next Plenty to come.

Such was the way of the land, Vendredi supposed.

She had experienced much within her time through these lands. Fought, lived and bled through every season this cycle had to offer.

Thus, riding towards Kunafa Village next to Alma, she tensed when the first sound of thunder pierced through the plains.

“...Hear that?” She commented, meeting Alma’s frown with her own.

Dark clouds quickly covered the sky as wind began to blow harder, the sand beneath their mounts’ feet slowly rising. A flash of lightning erupted through the plains as herds of Ceratonoths began flowing out of the valley in panic.

“That’s not good.” She heard Bawlz say from behind her, she could feel the Felyne shifting his weight to take a good look around. “Think Nata’s doing okay?”

The question knocked the breath out of her for a second. Nata was a good kid, but it was dangerous for *anyone* to be out alone during the Inclemency. Not just because of the natural catastrophes happening all around, but also because of the Monsters. Because the true King of the land was thriving during the season. Because lesser Monsters would flee, terrified.

Vendredi shivered. She knew firsthand the dangers of a frightened hoard of Monsters.

She looked at Alma. The Handler's face spoke for her -- she was worried sick, trapped in her own thoughts of the worst case scenario.

She looked ahead, staring at the plains battered by the first winds of a rising sandstorm.

"He has to be." Vendredi stated with a tone that left no doubt for doubt. "Either he's still in Kunafa taking refuge, or he's already on his way back to camp -- he'll get there before the storm gets too bad."

She turned back towards Alma, giving her a gentle smile and a squeeze of her shoulder, handling her Seikret with only one hand.

"He'll be fine Alma. He's a smart cookie."

She met her gaze, already more composed. "... Right." She said.

Vendredi let out a relieved breath, seizing back her mount's reins with both hands. "Okay. Let's take shelter too. We don't want to be caught out here."

"Kunafa's close now." Bawlz intervened, his back pressed against hers so he could look at the map. "Why not go there?"

Vendredi quizzed Alma with a look for her opinion. "Well," the Handler pondered. "It was our original destination afterall. And we can see if Nata's still there."

Vendredi nodded. "Kunafa it is. Hold on tight, Bawlz."

Her Seikret took off with a flick of her wrists, followed closely by Alma's as they rushed through the rising storm.

It was mere minutes until they came into view of Kunafa's gate. The sand village was lodged tight within the cracks of a canyon, carved deep into the walls of a cliff. They could hear the hundreds of wind chimes adorned high above the roofs throughout the whole village, whistling loudly with the storm.

Vendredi remembered thinking it to be some kind of elaborate weather alarm when they first came across the village. She had since learned that the sound made by the

chimes mimicked the cry of the region's Apex Monster, scaring away any would-be intruders.

She found it brilliant.

She practically jumped down her Seikret when she reached the gate. An agitated man argued with two guards standing by the entrance, barring the way. They wore rudimentary weapons and armor, the concept of hunting Monsters still foreign to the common people of the Forbidden Lands.

Vendredi walked toward the group as Alma and Bawlz dismounted beside her.

"Hey!" She called, waving a hand to catch their attention.

The people turned to her, pausing their argument to meet their arrival.

"Sorry to interrupt you, folks! We were travelling here when the storm hit, and we wondered if-"

"Y'sai?" Alma interrupted from her side, looking at the agitated man.

Sure enough, now that Vendredi looked, this ***was*** Y'sai, looking disheveled. He wore civilian Kunafan clothing, consisting of a pale white sleeveless top with a dark green scarf. His long, dark hair was loose for once, flowing around his tan shoulders marked with tattoos.

She frowned. She hadn't seen the man so careless with his appearance since his younger sister disappeared.

"Shit- Y'sai, is Nona okay?"

"Hunter!" He cried, urgency bleeding through his voice. "She- she is but- my Mother. She was out when the Inclemency hit. Nata was home for a meal but-"

He gulped.

"He ran out when he learned. He said he'd bring her back and rode off on a Seikret."

Vendredi's heart missed a beat.

"Oh no." Alma visibly paled. "If he's…" She trailed off, the worst case scenarios clouding the Handler's mind.

"Hey." Vendredi interrupted her spiral with a gentle gloved hand to her shoulder. "He'll be fine. I trained him, didn't I?" She whispered with a cocky grin that didn't reach her eyes.

Alma seemed to compose herself at that, taking a deep breath with closed eyes. "Still," she eventually said. "I don't like the thought of him being alone out there."

“Me neither.” Vendredi’s smile fell. She shook her head, flames burning in her eyes. “But we’ll get him back. I promise.” Alma nodded in silent agreement.

Y’sai flinched at that intensity, but to his credit, recovered quickly. “He went North-West,” he supplied. “Towards the sand dunes. Mother was headed to the Oasis before the storm.”

Vendredi thanked him as Alma climbed back on her Seikret, fishing out sand gear out of a pocket. A green scarf quickly covered her mouth and nose as sand goggles replaced her regular ones. The Hunter jumped back on her own mount, her own scarf and goggles in place in a flash.

“Let's brave a sandstorm.”

Nata had messed up.

Shame, it seemed a good idea at first.

He had been just ready to head back to camp, standing by the entrance of Y’sai’s home, when the Inclemency suddenly washed over the land. The man had shouted at the guards over the whistling chimes about his Mother, out by the Oasis. Cries of disbelief had filled the streets-- “Old Nana?” “What was she thinking?” “I’m sorry, but I can’t let you go!”

What would Vendredi do? He had thought to himself then. The answer had been obvious.

She’d have been a hero.

She wouldn’t have hesitated, jumping on a Seikret and rushing out in a flash, Palico and Handler in tow. She’d have risked her life, braving the storm in the Inclemency, grabbed the elderly woman, and brought her home without breaking a sweat.

So, that was the plan at first.

He had acted on instinct, jumping onto the back of the first Seikret he spotted. All those riding lessons had paid off -- he *almost* didn’t lose balance. The mount had headed out in panic on its own, but thankfully in the general direction he intended to go towards.

It had then taken a few minutes to get control of his ride, but the Seikret eventually fell back on its training when faced with the worst of the storm, trusting fully in its rider. From there, it had been child's play to find the Oasis, as well as Old Nana, hiding by the cover of a large rock.

He didn’t lose any time, helping Y’sai’s mother on the Seikret, giving her his own and only set of sand gear -- he really didn’t think this through -- and heading back

towards the village. It was only after crossing the first dune that things had gone South.

The thunderstorm had grown merciless, flashes of lightning the only thing Nata could see through the thick moving walls of sand that covered his vision. A bolt had landed close -- too close to the Seikret, and the beast had panicked. He had lost control of the ride who, to his horror, bolted in the **opposite direction** from the village.

Now, he was holding on for dear life, hugging the beast's neck tight with both arms, regretting each and every decision that had led to this situation.

He'd known he'd messed up the moment his mount bolted -- but now, tossed through the storm with no control, it finally hit him. The Seikret was running and jumping frantically, and without any sense of direction, Nata couldn't know where the creature was taking them. The old woman he was *supposed* to save was holding on admirably, as if she had done this all her life-- at this point, he thought, it would be **him** that would need saving.

Things only grew worse and worse as deep snarls echoed over the storm between cracks of thunder. The Seikret slammed into something -- a massive wall of moving muscles. The mount soon found itself trapped in a sea of brown and dirty yellow fur, thankfully cutting off the worst of the sandstorm. Nata felt relief for a second before realizing the mess he had gotten himself into.

His ride had run right into a Doshaguma herd.

The towering bear-shaped creatures with lion-like manes moved efficiently through the storm, huddled together to protect each other from the sand. Every individual of the carnivorous herd was ***huge***, easily scaling at the size of a tree when they stood on their hind legs.

The monsters were fleeing the sandstorm, unbothered by their new companion as they trampled vegetation and small monsters alike without a care. The Seikret kept pace, somehow finding itself huddled between the messy pile of moving limbs.

A sudden bolt of thunder hit the ground next to the group, sending the beasts barrelling to the side. The Seikret followed.

Then another. And another. The storm was getting worse and worse, flashes of lightning becoming more and more frequent as the herd desperately fled away from the thunder and into the walls of a wide canyon, wide cliffs forming a winding path.

And then they reached a dead end.

Nata pulled hard on the Seikret reins, stopping the creature from smashing into a Doshaguma's side as the herd flowed into a wide arena. The ground was covered with black and blue crystals littered everywhere, repeatedly struck by small arcs of

electricity coming from the sky. Static built all over the ground, making each strike burst like an explosion.

That was when he realized.

This was a nest.

The thunder that guided the herd wasn't random.

They had been corralled here by--

His trail of thoughts was interrupted by a piercing, haunting ***roar***.

Nata looked up at the sky and froze.

A golden speck pierced the clouds above, unbothered by the storm that swallowed the sun. It grew and grew, until the shape of a flying wyvern filled the skies. Crystals -- the same as the nest's -- glittered across its wings, four horns framed its head like a crown.

The King of the lands that *thrived* in the chaos of the storm was here, the region's apex that Kunafa both feared and revered through their wind chimes.

The Rey Dau.

Nata hid a whimper as he looked for a way out -- *they had to flee the nest at all cost* -- but there was no hope. The fallen bodies of Doshaguma, sizzling with electricity and stampeded to death, formed an actual barrier of roasted flesh and broken bones his Seikret couldn't jump over without a running start. The exit was blocked.

What little was left of the herd clawed frantically at their comrades' remains, trying with desperation to find a way out. The Rey Dau roared once more from the sky, its horns realigning in front of its head as electricity was building up.

"Boy!" The old woman yelled over the storm. "Take cover!"

Right- he had forgotten she was here. He shook himself back into action, guiding the Seikret behind the protection of a Doshaguma's corpse. A low hum filled the air, growing ever more potent- until thunder **burst** from the Rey Dau's horns like the shot of a railgun.

The nest **exploded** with a blinding detonation that left his ears painfully ringing. When Nata's senses finally came back to him, the calm hush of the storm was all he could hear.

There wasn't a whimper, a snarl, a roar, a breathing.

Every beast that once stood in the nest laid down on the ground, burnt alive by the wrath of a thunder god. It was only by pure luck that he wasn't with them right now.

Before he could catch his breath, the Rey Dau hit the ground with a heavy sound, landing in the middle of the nest amongst the bodies of its prey.

So yeah.

Nata knew he had royally, absolutely messed up.

What would Vendredi do? He asked himself.

She would have drawn her weapon, drove the beast away and rode back to the village, Old Nana in tow.

He stepped down from his Seikret without a word, drawing the beginner's sword and shield the Hunter gave him lessons with.

His hands, his whole body was *shaking* as he stared down at the monster, the Thunder Wyvern eyeing him with the gaze only a wolf could give a rabbit.

Who was he kidding-- he was no hero. He could never dream of being like her. He was just a kid, playing pretend.

His mind was swirling with thoughts and panic as his body fell into trained posture. He barely registered the old woman he was supposed to rescue, yelling at him from the Seikret's back. Nata was engrossed in the all-consuming bright red glare of the beast in front of him.

For a second, he was a child again, back at Wyveria. The White Wraith-- no, the **Arkveld** burnt down houses in a burning, twisted rage. Its wrath felt deeply, deeply wrong and disturbing. He could only watch, powerless, as the crazed monster ripped apart his neighbour in half with its claws, red human blood coating its white maw.

He was scared. No, he was *terrified*.

His breathing grew quicker, sharper. The world started to blur all around.

He was going to die.

He was going to die.

He was going to die. He didn't want to die. He wanted to go back to the arms of Tasheen. He wanted to travel with the Alvis Unit. He wanted to train under the Hunter, become just like her, integrate the ways of the Guild into the culture of his people.

He didn't want to die.

Tears flew freely from his eyes, his grip on the sword's hilt faltered and the weapon fell to the ground.

The Ark- **the Rey Dau** took a step in his direction, more intrigued than threatened by the boy that had stepped into its nest.

He could feel *power* exalted by the Apex purely by virtue of existing. Every step was a statement of its strength, cracking the ground with ripples of electricity that spread over the whole nest. Its wings were tuckered to its chest, heaving heavily with every breath. Little electric arcs flickered between its horns like tesla coils. It produced a low, curious rumble, sounding like broken glass.

The storm was still raging overhead, thunder hit the arena here and there-- but the beast was undisturbed. A bolt hit it straight in the back. The wyvern didn't even flinch or slow its approach, merely flicking its head in annoyance as the power rippled into the crystals on the ground.

Nata couldn't move. Couldn't breathe. Armed only with a shield -- a make-believe shield -- he stood there, motionless, as the beast approached.

Finally, when the Rey Dau reached him, he closed his eyes. He didn't even bother covering up his shaking, absorbed into visions of the past. He felt the beast's *breath*, a single curious sniff threatening to knock him over.

He gritted his teeth-- no. It couldn't end like this.

"H-HEY!" He yelled stupidly, desperately, right into the Apex's face. "BACK OFF!"

He swung his shield arm around, just like at practice, hoping to do… whatever he could do.

But as he did so he overshot his reach, tripping on his own sword left on the ground, hitting the side of his shield with more force than intended into the beast's *nostril*.

The monster flinched, surprised by the sudden aggressive act of what it thought was easy prey. It didn't appreciate that, glaring down at the boy with a mixture of disbelief and hatred.

Nata himself was left sprawled on the ground, equally in disbelief at what he just did. He scrambled to his feet, watching with horror as the Rey Dau beat his wings, taking off to hover over the ground in an instant.

Its horns rearranged themselves into the form of a rail gun, electricity building up to the head from its whole body as a low deathly hum took over the arena. He rushed to get back to his feet-- but found his foot caught under a rock.

He looked back at his captor, charging up a death beam.

What would Vendredi do? He asked himself.

"BAWLZ! FLASHPOD!" A shout too loud to be the voice from his head answered.

Huh?

A pod flew into his field of vision, right between him and the Monster. He recognized it instantly, shielding his eyes with his arm as a *blinding flash* exploded into the arena the moment it hit the ground.

When he opened his eyes again he saw the Rey Dau fallen to the ground, dazed from the blast. Footsteps were approaching quickly and, before he could comprehend what was happening, they reached him.

He watched in awe as Vendredi was there -- *was really there!* -- stopping her Seikret next to him and using its saddle as a platform for jumping high into the air.

She flew gracefully, white scarf flowing wild against the dark of the storm, two red blades in her hands. Then -- *he could swear he saw a red flash in her eyes and a demonic grin on her lips* -- she shot a grapple at the Monster's wing, shifting her momentum with the speed of a bullet. Her blades twirled as she flew past a lightning bolt, soon carving deep into its wing scales. Vendredi didn't stop there, using her momentum to keep going further up the beast's wing arm, back, and then back down its *other arm* before landing nimbly next to the boy without as much as taking a breath.

The Rey Dau roared in pain and fury, reeling back from the fury of blows it suffered out of nowhere.

The Hunter of the Alvis Unit was here.

He couldn't help but gape as she bent down to check on him, an amused raised eyebrow hiding a relieved expression behind sand goggles. She had a wide, cocky grin on her face, marred with an old scar on the right side of her lips. She chuckled -- *she chuckled* --, unbothered by the storm, as she offered him a hand up.

"Hey." Vendredi rasped, voice thick with a mixture of a thousand emotions he couldn't decipher.

Vendredi watched the boy, sprawled on the ground with wide eyes, as she reached out her hand.

She *should* feel tired. She had rode her Seikret at maximum speed through the storm, pushing the mount to its limits while Bawlz shouted contradictory directions over the thunder and a panicked Alma in tow. She had arrived just in the nick of time, attacking the Rey Dau with all she had *just to buy some time*.

But she wasn't. She felt good, exalted, alive. **Relieved**. He was safe-- thank Gog he was safe. The kid had various minor scraps here and there, his sand gear was

noticeably gone (probably handed off to Old Nana), but he was **safe**. He stared up at her like a moth discovering the sun, probably a little shaken.

“Hey.” She croaked out. The Monster roared in pain behind her, trying to make sense of what happened. She paid it no mind.

“Might wanna get off the floor.” She winked playfully, voice gentle with a hint of seriousness. “Let’s go home kid. Alright?”

Nata finally shook out of his stupor, taking her hand as she rose him up to his feet. “R-right.” He said, voice shaking. Her heart swelled for the kid, trying and failing desperately to look strong.

“ALMA!” She called. “OVER HERE!”

Footsteps approached rapidly as Nata seemed to make himself as small as possible, grabbing his sword from the ground as discreetly as he could, likely hoping Vendredi didn’t see him.

She did. But made no comment, leaving him be for the moment to check on Old Nana and her son’s Seikret. The elder seemed in her element, very much thankful for her and Nata’s intervention but not worried in the slightest, trusting fully into the Hunter that had defended her village time and time again.

When Vendredi turned back to Nata, the boy was smothered into a tight hug by Alma and Bawlz, her partner pulling back frowning a moment after to fret over the boy with a thousand questions he couldn’t begin to answer. Vendredi smiled fondly at the sight, before taking a glimpse at the still reeling Monster in the middle of the arena.

Right. That was a problem.

The storm was still raging on, thunder growing more and more furious as if swayed by the rising temper of the Rey Dau. The beast looked at her with what could only be described as pure and unadulterated **hatred**, snarling as it evaluated its aggressor.

“Alma.” She cut through the Handler’s lecture without breaking eye contact with the creature, tone serious. “Get Nata some gear and bring him and Old Nana back to the village. I’ll hold it off.”

Nata looked like he was about to argue but Alma put a placating arm on his shoulder, shooting him a gentle look. She then nodded at Vendredi. “Alright. It goes without saying but,” she cleared her throat, “the Guild authorizes you to hunt this creature. With the way it is, it would follow us back to Kunafa otherwise.”

Vendredi shook her head. “Understood. I-”

She didn’t get to finish before a piercing cry cut her off, echoing through the nest. The Rey Dau, finally out of its daze, was on the attack. She turned her attention back

to it, drawing her weapon with Bawlz at her side, while Alma and Nata ran back to their Seikrets. But as she rushed towards the Monster, rising in the air while charging up electricity for its devastating railgun-thunderblast, she watched in horror as it chose its target.

She could swear the beast gave her a mocking look as it turned its head towards Alma and Nata.

'No.'

Vendredi *bolted* to her Seikret, abandoning her blades here and there on the ground. She reached the mount in two steps, not stopping as she drew her secondary weapon from the saddle, a sword and shield. She kept going, using the mount as a footstool to *launch* herself forward, landing at the ready with a roll right between the Monster and its target.

She only had a fraction of a millisecond to get into position, shield arm at the ready.

It was all she needed, planting her feet firmly into the ground, left arm forward.

'Not again.' She thought.

The bolt came, lightning fast and devastating, exploding with the detonation of a thousand bombs on her shield.

Vendredi held strong, shield arm reeling from the blast but not moving an inch. Pain coursed through it.

Then the worst came. The shield couldn't protect her from *all* the electricity blasted at her, and some pushed through the handle. It *had* to go somewhere.

She felt as if she was struck by lightning, her nerves twitching as the energy passed through her and into the ground. Her muscles locked. The taste of metal filled her mouth. She was as a lightning rod propped against a thunderstorm. And, by the end of it, when the smoke cleared, she was still standing.

Vendredi smiled.

The Monster watched her with bloodlust, rage and hint of respect. She stared back, defiant, adrenaline kicking in. She threw a glance above her shoulder, checking to see if Alma and Nata were okay.

Her partner hadn't wasted any time, already pulling the both of them on top of her Seikret beside Old Nana's. The Handler gave her a thankful smile she returned, before turning back to the task at hand.

Or rather she would have.

“HUNTER!” Nata yelled out, grabbing her full attention. She looked at him with a raised eyebrow as he seemed to search for his next words.

“...Be safe.” He finally settled on.

Vendredi snorted, shooting him a cocky grin and a wave of her fingers.

“Always am, kiddo!”

Hearing the Seikrets easily jumping over a Doshaguma’s body and rushing off, she finally turned back to the Rey Dau.

The Monster snarled at her, thunder coating its scales.

She snarled back with a grin. “Show me what you’ve got, you yellow looking son of a bi-”

Ch3 - A Hunter’s Confession

Base Camp was bustling with activity and agitation tonight. Researchers argued loudly over their latest finds, their tent glowing in the dark. Hunters roared drunken chants at the canteen while Felyne chefs raced to stack meals. Handlers muttered about the noise, quills scratching over neglected paperwork. The market buzzed with activity as stock was resupplied and sales were being made, travelling merchants shouting deals over the cacophony of the crowd. The forge echoed with a concert of metal sounds and the roar of flames, smithies working through repairs and commissions for the next day.

All in all, a typical evening for the Guild outpost of the Windward Plains.

Though, a short walk away from all the lights and noise, someone sat at the edge of the cliff overlooking the plains. There, all faded as the only sound was the soft crackle of a lantern and the rhythmic sound of a blade being sharpened. Braided twintails rested over the figure’s shoulder, discarded gear and armor scattered around on the ground.

Stillness had returned to the valley below. The storm, once blowing sand and lightning with the fury of the gods, was now reduced to little more than a breeze carrying the quiet hum of nature.

A hum the figure echoed with a quiet smile and a distant look in their eyes.

Vendredi sat there, a single leg casually dangling over the ledge as if gravity didn’t have a pull on her. She wore comfortable casual clothing -- a red sleeveless linen shirt, high-waisted pale cargo shorts cinched with a leather belt, light fingerless gloves and ankle boots -- as her armor was off, the pieces stained red with blood littering the ground. Dual blades rested in her lap along with her shield as she sharpened a sword’s blade.

Schling. *Schling*. *Schling*.

She never was good with stillness.

She had learned to bear it, even come to relish the peace over the years. But, even now, it was the *thrill* of action that made her feel truly alive. The *rush* of movement, the *adrenaline* of the fall.

She sighed, pausing her work to look over the blade.

That Rey Dau had put up one hell of a fight. But in the end, as always, she prevailed. Nata was safe. Old Nana was returned to her home. She had paid her reverence to nature, then brought her own family to safety.

Satisfied with her work, she put the blade aside.

Wordlessly, she rested her elbow on her knee, eyes wandering across the sleeping plains. What would *she* think, if she saw her now? If she saw them?

She huffed in amusement. Yeah. She would have loved the kid.

Speaking of- she could hear familiar footsteps approaching from camp. Shaking herself back into action, she reached for one of her dual blades as she resumed the sharpening process.

Soon enough, the steps stopped. Without even looking, Vendredi could feel the nervousness in their posture, the hesitation bubbling up their throat.

“... Hey.” Nata’s voice came, small and shy in the way a kid who knew he messed up was.

“Hey kid,” she saluted without turning towards him, her tone light as she worked away at her blade. “Alma finally stopped fretting over you?”

She heard the boy sigh. “I wish. But Bawlz said I’d better come here before it gets too dark.”

At that, Vendredi paused, looking at the night sky. She turned back towards the boy, an eyebrow raised and an amused smile on her face. “Took your sweet time then, huh?”

“No! I-” he stuttered, an embarrassed mess as he tried to explain his misadventures. Something about having to bribe the Felyne with dinner, getting a stern lecture from an elder who had learned of his escapades, and getting lost on the way in the maze of the market.

“Calm down! Calm down!” Vendredi put up a placating hand, holding back a giggle. “It’s okay kid, I get it.”

He closed his mouth, unsure what to do next. She sighed, patting the ground next to her.

“Come, sit.”

Nata moved forward, face reserved that spoke volume to how much he dreaded this conversation -- something told her didn’t get quite as lost as he pretended on the way here. Not that she blamed him. It is hard feeling you failed someone you admire, after all.

He finally sat cross-legged beside her as she resumed sharpening with a quiet hum. The silence stretched for a while as she worked, the kid’s eyes alternating between her, her weapons and the plains. She didn’t say a word, letting him find his own.

Schling. *Schling*. *Schling*.

“I’m sorry.” He finally said. The confession hung there for a moment, heavy in the light of the lantern.

The fire crackled, distant laughter echoing from the camp.

“What for?” Vendredi asked, tone light. She didn’t look away from the blade. She didn’t need to, to feel his eyes on her face, watchful for *any* sign.

“I messed up.” He rasped. “I- I didn’t think, back there. I was too caught up in… trying to be you, I- I acted too rashly.”

She paused, looking over her blade. This one was only used in the Chatacabra hunt, earlier this day-- so it wasn’t as damaged as the sword. It already looked good. She put it aside on the ground, the *cling* cutting through the tension.

She still didn’t look at the boy, instead raising up her head at the stars.

“You don’t need to be sorry to me, kid.” She declared, looking for one particular light in the sky. “You did something stupid, but brave. You thought what you did was right. That’s good. I’m proud of that.”

Then, she found it. *Her* star.

A smile clung to her lips as she turned, looking Nata directly in the eyes.

“What you did was dumb. There’s no other way of putting it. It’s also done. No what-ifs, no take-backs. It’s in the past. What matters -- the **only** thing that matters -- is that you learn from it.”

She shrugged as he watched, somewhere between awed and conflicted. “You’ve made a mistake. So what? You’ll make plenty more. And each time, you get back up, and you keep going. That’s what’s important.”

She paused, raising a finger to her chin in thought. “Well… that, ***and*** making it up for Alma. She was scared for you, you know?”

‘I was too’ was unsaid, but the kid was too smart for his own good. He’d figure it out anyway.

He sighed, his heart still heavy but a bit lighter than before, a smile now tugging on his lips. He nodded with energy, a spark in his eyes.

“I will. Thanks, Hunter.”

She snickered, ruffling up his hair affectionately. “Don’t mention it, kiddo. We all love you, y’know.”

He went to answer- but was cut off by a yawn. She chuckled at the sight.

“Go on, head back to camp kid. Get some sleep, the lecture can wait until tomorrow.”

The tension lifted from his body, the boy slumped his head against her shoulder. “...Don’t wanna.” He muttered, sleepily.

Her eyes softened. “Stay here for a while then. But I’m taking you back to camp as soon as I’m done here.”

Nata frowned at the proposal, but eventually nodded-- still while slumped against her shoulder.

She kept working at her gear for a while, eventually switching to cleaning off the pieces of her armor. She could feel the kid dozing, not quite asleep, sometimes stirring just to watch her work.

It felt good. She was using a handkerchief -- Alma’s, she’d make sure to clean it before returning it to her -- to scrub off dried blood from her Arkveld-plated gloves, the long chains swinging like a pendulum.

It was just as she finished one finger that Nata spoke again, in a drowsy tone.

“How…” His voice broke. She paused, giving him space, patience, and her full attention. “How do you go on with… with fear?”

“B-back there,” his tone was fragile. “I- I froze. I… I thought I saw… ***it*** again, for a moment.” His eyes were fixated on the gloves.

“I- You… You’re fearless. No matter what happens. You always move like- like nothing could ever stop you. Like fear isn’t even a concept for you. How…”

He shifted his head to look at her face, bathed in the dim glow of the moon. She could feel him commit each and every piece of it to memory.

“How do I become like you?” He whispered, his voice breaking again at the end.

The question knocked the breath out of her. The night suddenly felt too quiet.

She didn’t move an inch.

Then, putting the glove down, she finally spoke.

“Here’s the secret, kid.”

He perked up, eyes wide awake.

She leaned towards him, careful not to slip his head from her shoulder, whispering to his ear.

“*I’m scared too*.”

Leaning back, she could see a mixture of disbelief and confusion in his eyes. She giggled, looking up at the stars as she started gently stroking his head, an arm over his shoulder.

“Let me tell you a story, okay?”

She could feel him pout without looking. “...I’m not a kid. I don’t need a bedtime story.” He protested sleepily.

She chuckled. “C’mooon, it will be fun!”

He sighed, shifting closer to nestle his cold body into her warmth. “...‘kay.” He conceded, still pouting.

She took a deep breath.

The night breeze picked up, tugging gently at her twintails. She smiled to herself.

“There were once, two little girls.” She started. “Twins, actually. They lived in a quiet but peaceful village, one whose name got lost to the sands of time. A village near a place called Kamura.”

“The first, Yoko, had a knack for getting into trouble. She was quite energetic, this one. Always looking for a chance to cause mischief, to make her sister laugh.” A smile tugged on her face.

“The second one, Tsuki, was quieter. Shy, reserved.” The smile turned sadder. “But when she was laughing, her face lit up the night like the sun. She was deeply caring towards everyone, even motherly to those younger than her.”

She huffed, her smile lighting up again. “The two of them cared deeply for one another, always doing everything together from the moment of their birth. They never left each other’s side, no matter what. When Yoko broke the elder’s favorite vase, Tsuki talked things out. When Tsuki got bullied by older kids, Yoko roughed them up.”

She sighed. “...Now, if you know anything about Kamura -- pay attention kid, it *will* come up in your history exams -- you know about the Calamity. Wide packs of frenzied monsters razing the village of Old Kamura, forcing the surviving villagers to relocate.”

“What’s less known about the Calamity, is that it… didn’t hit *just* Old Kamura. Other villages in the valley were affected too.”

“YOKO!”

Tsuki’s voice rang over the cacophony of screams, blood and roars outside. The seven-year-old's first thought was that she’d never heard her sister’s voice so loud before.

Yoko took a moment to register the world around her, for a moment focused entirely on her twin’s appearance. Thankfully spared by the end of their world, her twin looked at her with teary eyes, only covered with grime, dirt and dust -- but without any noticeable injury.

Tsuki rushed to her side, her movement limited by the debris. Her once elegant blue gown tore on a rock, her bare feet ached as she stepped on rubble, but she didn’t stop.

Her sister was there before Yoko could form a coherent thought, holding her in her arms while patting circles on her back.

“Shhh, shhh, there…” Tsuki whispered in her ear, as if calming a wailing child.

Then, Yoko realized that was exactly what she was, at that moment. The Monsters had burst from the night, breaking through the village’s defense and tearing through their home, neighbours, friends and family. Yoko had grabbed her sister’s wrist and run through the streets, desperate for somewhere, anywhere, to hide. A building had collapsed on top of them, burying them under debris. And now, trapped in the dark at the center of unimaginable chaos, she could feel her sister’s arms around her, uncaring for the blood dripping from Yoko’s lip staining her dress.

It was too much. She was terrified. Tsuki’s voice, ever so gentle and confident, was shaking too. But they needed to be silent, so that the Monsters wouldn’t find them. So, a hand still rubbing her back, Yoko forced herself to cry in silence as they clung tightly to each other.

They stayed like that for ten hours.

The voices outside eventually subsided, the roars and steps of Monsters got quieter, leaving only an eerie silence broken only by the crackles of flames. The twins still didn’t say a word, didn’t dare break apart from each other.

Then, finally, some noise broke the suffocating quiet. Shouts of people, muffled by the debris.

They froze, unsure what to do. Would it be safe? Who were these people? As they shifted to listen to the sounds, Tsuki stepped on a sharp pebble, unable to contain a painfully loud whimper.

The voices heard. Shouts got louder as steps approached their location, the sound of moving rock and grunts of effort filling the void. Light finally pierced through their shelter.

A man stood in front of them at the entrance, wearing heavy azure-blue armor. The scales that covered it reminded Yoko of the Monsters that razed her home. She couldn't see his eyes through the helmet.

He reached a hand to them. She shifted her position to put herself between the man and Tsuki, picking up a metal bar from the debris and holding it like a make-believe sword, raised at the intruder.

"S-STAY BACK!" She yelled, throat hoarse.

The man in armor paused, taking back his hand slowly. He moved with careful movements, as if to make sure she could track every inch of his actions. He put his hands to his helmet, tugging at the sides as she tensed.

Then, he removed it, tossing it behind without a care.

He looked kind of old, scars and lines giving his face a soft but firm look. His hair, black like them both, had subtle gray strays here and there.

His eyes were kind. Gentle.

"You're okay kid." He said, a deep voice she could almost believe. "You're okay."

"...And so, that Friday, their world ended." Vendredi continued, aware of Nata's now full attention from her shoulder. The smell of smoke subsided, replaced by the desert's gentle breeze.

"Tsuki and Yoko were the only survivors of their home village and, as such, they had nowhere to go. So, they followed the Hunter to the Guild."

She closed her eyes, reminiscing. "Thus, just like you, they decided to become Hunters."

Vendredi smiled, a hand coming to rest on the hilt of her blade. "Even after everything, they still had each other. And so, to them, it was all that mattered. They soon blossomed into full-fledged Hunters, quickly becoming a fearsome duo that rose in reputation at the Guild.

"Yoko was still as hot-headed as ever, a storm of aggression and agility in combat that never let up. Tsuki, in contrast, was way more level headed-- she chose defense and support that covered and created opportunities for her teammate. They truly complemented each other, becoming widely known as the duo of the Sun and Moon."

She turned to Nata, eyes wide as he absorbed each information like groundbreaking knowledge. She winked at the boy. "Which one was the Sun and the Moon, no one could ever agree on that."

Her expression turned more wistful. “Life was good for the twins. Not perfect though -- the tragedy still followed their memory. And, despite actively trying to dress and style their hair differently, people still had a… hard time telling them apart.” She absentmindedly raised a hand to the scar on her lip, eyes distant, unaware of the boy’s attention to the action.

“And so- Tsuki, sweet, shy and reclusive Tsuki, did something radical. There was this… comical, boastful Hunter travelling through a town they were staying at. A ‘hero on a journey’, as he described himself with a purple disco-ball shaped haircut. More of a buffoon if you’d ask Yoko. But, Tsuki found the man incredibly inspiring, endearing, and most of all-- hilarious.”

She cleared her throat with a laugh, unaware of the wetness of her eyes.

“So, Tsuki decided one night, on a whim, to dye her hair purple. That way, no one would ever mistake them both again.”

She grinned, true. “It worked. Yoko became recognizable through her black ponytail while, despite her subdued nature, Tsuki brought attention with braided purple twintails.”

Silence settled for a moment, a desert breeze flowing through her hair. She looked to the stars as she breathed slowly, a hand stroking the boy’s hair. Nata stayed quiet, listening to her breathing.

“Things were good,” she eventually said, “for the twins.”

Vendredi closed her eyes, gathering a big breath. “But, like all things, it didn’t last.”

“They took on a hunt they shouldn’t have. Faced something that shouldn’t be faced. That was bigger than nature. The battle dragged on for too long, they grew tired, desperate. Yoko was too reckless, and she missed a step.”

She kept her eyes closed. Nata didn’t need to see what haunted them.

“... Tsuki stepped in, as she usually did. Raised her shield, intercepting the blow for her sister. Only, this time she… didn’t get back up.”

The silence felt heavy. Important.

For once, Vendredi let it be.

Yoko slid down the beast’s ebony hide before its lifeless head even hit the ground, shaking the arena with its weight. She didn’t bother praying for it -- there was nothing to pray to. She ran.

A sickening trail of blood led her to the wall she was resting against. Shield and lance laid carelessly on the ground beside her, a gaping hole in her armor in the

shape of a sharp claw. Empty healing potion bottles littered the ground, ineffective against the depth of the wound.

She looked pale.

Yoko was at her side in an instant, uncaring for her own wounds -- shallow in comparison. “No, no no no no no no-” she muttered uselessly through her vision blurred with tears. She clung to her, holding her tightly. “Don’t- You can’t- I-”

“H-hey.” Tsuki hissed through the pain, her voice somehow calm, even now. Like she already knew what came next, and had accepted it. She had a warm smile, a hand on the wound, cradling Yoko’s face with the other. “Shhhh… it’s okay.”

“N-no.” Yoko pleaded shakily, holding on to her hand like it was the most precious thing in the world (it was). “D-don’t go. I-I-I can’t- I can’t do this without you. Don’t-”

A soft, bright chuckle cut through the air. Tsuki wiped the tears from face, the gesture soft and simple.

“Of course you can, silly!” She cheered with a smile. “You’re strong. You’ll-” her voice broke, her mask of peace and confidence wavering.

Tsuki closed her eyes, voice shaky. “You’ll be fine, sis! You’ll- You’ll look at the stars in the night sky and know I’m there, watching you. Forever and always. You’ll live for us both.”

Yoko smiled, a soul-crushing weight pressing down over her heart. She caressed her sister’s hair gently, brushing off blood and grime as she held her hand tightly over her chest.

“I… I promise I will, sis.”

And so, she held her, as peace settled over her sister’s face.

And so, something broke in her that day.

Vendredi sighed, opening her eyes again to find the same star in the sky.

She had stopped caressing the kid’s hair at some point. So, with a hum, she resumed, letting the silence fall.

“...That Friday,” she broke it eventually, “about five years ago, Yoko’s world ended. She kept trying to go on afterwards, but she couldn’t. She soon found herself unable to hunt properly, having to adjust the loss of her second half. And so, eventually, she left. To fulfill her promise -- to live for them both.”

“...To find herself again.” Vendredi said, running a hand through her hair

“It took her a long time, but she did so. She travelled the world, met so many people, trained with legends, picked up some new weapons and changed her name, look and identity -- but she did so. She found herself.”

She turned to meet the boy’s eyes with a wink. “But that,” she ruffled his head, ignoring his complaints, “is a story for another time.”

She pulled back her hand, taking back the glove she was previously cleaning from the ground. Using Alma’s handkerchief, she resumed her dirty work, scrubbing off dried blood and grime from the joints.

“So,” she said, without taking her eyes off her task, voice light. “Moral of the story -- sorry kid, there’s always a moral. Grief is difficult. Finding yourself, moving on after a tragedy… It’s hard. There’s no way about it. Don’t get too caught up about it, it’s just how it is.”

“But, that’s the thing. It gets easier with time. And a lot of effort. Yoko never was fearless, heck, I’d even argue that she was *defined* by fear. What’s important is how you use that fear. You can’t live without it.”

She turned the glove over in her hand, inspecting it. Finding her work satisfactory she put it aside, reaching for the next.

“Fear is healthy. Fear is your brain, protecting you. You can’t shove it down kid-- you need to learn to listen to it. It’s not a defect to be stomped out. It’s a wild animal that needs guidance. And you need to let other people help you with that.”

She smiled, sad, but hopeful. “To answer your earlier question, kid -- I’m not fearless. You can’t imagine how scared I was of losing you back there. Sorry to shatter the myth.”

“Don’t be.” Nata’s voice echoed out, for the first time after so long. It wasn’t sleepy anymore -- it was clear, conflicted, determined. “It’s time I see it. You’re a person, too.”

She hummed in acknowledgement. Quiet, but thankful.

The silence stretched. The desert breeze carried a cold wind, making the kid shiver as he snuggled closer to her. From there he finally saw it for the first time -- the small sadness in her eyes, the tiredness in her face.

She could tell a thousand questions were racing through his mind. About her name, about the smaller hunts on Fridays, about *her*. But the one he landed on gave her pause.

“Is…” He asked, small, hesitating. She hummed in encouragement. “Is… *she* the anniversary, next week?”

Her heart missed a beat. “How- how do you know about that?”

“I overheard Alma talk about something like that at camp with Bawlz.” He answered simply. “I’m not sure I was meant to hear about that. Do they…”

“Yeah.” She nodded. “They know.”

She sighed, and ruffled the kid’s head again, for good measure. “Well, right on the money, kiddo. Next Friday, it will have been five years since Tsuki passed away. I’m taking the day off.”

“Oh.”

The word echoed through the night. Simple, but not much else could be said. Then, just as Vendredi was about to resume working, he shifted to hug her. Tight.

She let go of the glove -- it wasn’t that important anyway -- and returned the hug in full. Tender, gentle.

“...Thanks, kid.” She whispered, his head resting against her neck. “I really needed that.”

As the minutes passed without either of them moving, she could feel Nata’s breathing starting to slow down. His body relaxed. His mind drifted off to a quieter, calmer place.

Just when she thought he had drifted to sleep, she heard the kid mumble something against her.

“Sorry?” She asked, shifting her ears closer to the child.

“...Your lip scar.” He muttered. She froze.

“...I think it’s pretty.”

And just like that, his consciousness lifted from this plane to the dream realm. Something warm burst into her chest, coiling along her heart like a warm blanket.

She looked up at the night sky, tears welling up in her eyes.

‘*You’d be proud of him, sis.*’

She hugged the kid tighter, hearing the sound of quiet footsteps -- Alma’s -- trying not to wake Nata while still making their presence known.

‘...*You’d be proud of me too, wouldn’t you?*’